

Heat, Hustle, and Heart: A Summer in New York City

I was nineteen when I moved to New York City, a kid with big dreams and a white chef's jacket that felt almost too clean for the kitchens I was about to enter. The city swallowed me whole in the best way possible. I lived in a tiny apartment on the Upper East Side, just a few subway stops from Midtown, where sirens mixed with car horns, people talking, and the constant noise of the city. Every morning, I walked past coffee carts and delis, smelling bagels and exhaust, and thought, This is where I'm supposed to be. I loved the energy of it, the late nights, the chaos, the feeling that anything could happen if I just kept moving.

That summer, I worked at two of the world's best restaurants, Eleven Madison Park and Oceana. Eleven Madison Park felt like another world. The kitchen was spotless and quiet, except for the sound of knives on cutting boards and chefs calling out orders. Everything mattered, from how a sauce was wiped on a plate to the posture of cooks on the line. The chefs moved fast and precise, and I realized that the dishes people saw were the result of work most people couldn't imagine.

I started at the bottom, which meant long hours, burns, and endless repetition. I spent hours cutting vegetables perfectly and organizing herbs until my hands smelled permanently like basil and thyme. Some tasks were exhausting, like the day I had to remove the casings from garden peas for eight hours straight. I wasn't allowed to talk, just work. The repetition stretched time into a quiet kind of torture, and my fingers ached from the tiny motions, but that was just part of the job.

Other days, I was on the line during service, plating dishes as quickly as I could. The head chef would hover over me, telling me I was too slow and that I didn't belong there. I remember one night I had spent hours on a dish, trying to make it perfect, and he threw it in the trash before it even left the counter. I felt crushed, but I kept going. That's just how it was.

The work was intense. Every dish had to be exact. Desserts could collapse if you made a mistake, sauces could separate, seafood had to be perfect. One wrong move meant starting over. It wasn't just about cooking; it was about thinking fast, staying calm, and surviving under constant pressure. I learned to carry multiple tasks at once, keep my station clean while the orders piled up, and anticipate what would happen next before anyone asked. Every day was a test, and there was no margin for error.

I remember one Friday night when the dining room was full and the orders kept coming in faster than I could process them. I had three dishes to finish at once, each with different plating instructions. The heat from the stoves pressed down on my back, and the sound of the ticket printer felt like a constant reminder that one mistake would be noticed immediately. The chef was in my ear, criticizing every move, and yet I had to focus on each plate like my life depended on it. I finished the dishes, and one of them was thrown away because it wasn't perfect. I wanted to quit, but I just started the next order.

Then came Oceana. Seafood had its own challenges. The smell of the ocean stayed in the walk-in fridge, and every dish demanded care and speed at the same time. I learned to fillet fish, prepare delicate dishes, and keep moving even when the kitchen felt chaotic. Sometimes, I would spend hours shucking oysters or portioning fish, careful not to cut myself while trying to keep up with the line. The sous chefs taught me how to plan ahead, clean as I went, and stay professional

even when someone was yelling at me. The pace was exhausting, but I learned skills no classroom could teach.

Despite the excitement, the stress caught up to me. I couldn't sleep, replaying mistakes in my head. I worried constantly about letting the chefs down. I would come home after midnight, my body aching, and lie in bed thinking about if this is what I really wanted to do for my life. Some nights, I cried without even knowing why. I was proud to be there, but I felt like I couldn't keep up. Slowly, the passion I had for cooking started to fade. I loved food, but I started to dread the day ahead.

Even with the pressure, I tried to enjoy the city. I liked walking around at night, exploring neighborhoods, and trying different foods. Sometimes I would sit on a bench and just watch the city go by, the people, the lights, the energy. Other times, I would go to Central Park, find a spot in the grass, and just rest. I liked discovering little things: a street performer playing guitar, a food cart selling something new, or a small café tucked away on a side street. Those moments reminded me there was life outside the kitchen; those moments kept me feeling alive.

I also found small ways to keep myself grounded in the kitchen. I would notice how a sauce changed as it reduced, the way a soufflé puffed in the oven, or the smell of bread baking in the early morning. Those details reminded me why I wanted to be a chef in the first place. Even when everything was going wrong, there were little victories that kept me going.

Eventually, I made the hardest decision of that summer: I cut my externship short. I told myself it was temporary, but I knew I needed to step away. It felt like giving up, and I was embarrassed. I had worked so hard to get there, but I was breaking down. I remember sitting in

my apartment after making the decision, hearing the city outside, feeling both relieved and sad. I had lost something, but I had also saved myself.

Looking back, it was the right choice. That experience tested me and pushed me in ways I didn't expect. It showed me that passion can't survive without balance, and that success means nothing if you lose yourself trying to achieve it. Stepping away helped me understand why I loved cooking, the creativity, the connection, and sharing something with others.

After New York, I spent time thinking about what I wanted to do next. I realized that while I loved food, I didn't want to be in the kitchen all the time, under that kind of pressure, dealing with the constant mental and physical stress. That experience helped me redirect my focus. I came to the University of Dayton and started exploring a degree in communications and business. It became clear to me that I could still be involved in the food industry, but in a different way, without the heat of the kitchen and the mental struggles that come with being a line cook. I could work in food media, restaurant management, or marketing and still use my skills and passion without burning myself out. That clarity came directly from everything I experienced in New York.

Over the past few years at UD, I've started to understand how much that summer shaped me. I approach my studies and work differently now. I can handle stress better because I know my limits. I can appreciate the small victories in my life and focus on what I enjoy without letting pressure take over. I still love cooking, but I don't want it to define my mental health or my identity. Instead, I'm learning how to combine my passion with skills that will allow me to work in food in a sustainable way, whether that's in business, communications, or marketing.

By the end of that summer, I was different. My hands were sore, my body tired, but my mind was clearer. I had survived something that felt impossible. Even now, I miss parts of it, the energy of the kitchen, walking home late at night, eating food I couldn't get anywhere else, and living in a city that never slowed down. New York shaped me in ways I'm still figuring out. It taught me that growth often happens in hard places, and that passion and pressure can exist together if you learn how to manage them. It also taught me the importance of knowing your limits and making decisions that protect your well-being.

Someday, I will go back to New York, not just for the restaurants or the energy, but for the version of myself that believed anything was possible. For all the stress and long nights, it was the happiest I had ever been, and it showed me who I want to be. Now, I'm focused on building a career that balances my love for food with skills in business and communications, so I can make an impact without sacrificing my mental health or personal life. That's the biggest lesson I took from my time in the city: passion is important, but it has to be sustainable.